‘running away’ from Zimithang. It also seemed Sen was least interested in the ground situation and had no words of advice for any of his subordinates. Obviously in Tawang at the insistence of Army HQ, this was General Sen’s first ever visit and he seemed extremely anxious for a helicopter to come and take him back to Tezpur.

THE BLIND MEN OF HINDUSTAN

During the two-day trek from Zimithang to Tawang, Kalyan Singh and Niranjan Prasad had arrived at the conclusion that by defending Tawang the Indians would be making the same error that they had made in Nam Ka Chu. Given the tactical unsuitability of the ground, and with the Chinese closing in from three sides, a decision to fight at Tawang would be unsound. Now Prasad told Sen that he had decided to withdraw from Tawang the next day, as the IV Corps assessment suggested that the Chinese would attack through Bum-la on the morning of 24 October.

Sen exploded, and lashed out at Prasad. The manner in which events unfolded on 20 October had made him and General Thapar look like fools. Kaul had been proved right about the tactical absurdity of holding the riverfront. Sen was astute enough to realize that even though Kaul was the architect of the Nam Ka Chu disaster, during the last phase he had changed his tune and this later assessment had proved true. Sen probably expected that he would now be held accountable. In the heated exchange that followed, Sen told Prasad to hold Bum-la at all costs and await the arrival of additional troops to reinforce Tawang. Sen knew the government would be loath to give up what was seen as the symbol of the entire conflict—the Tawang Monastery.

Prasad was equally firm on withdrawing from Tawang and taking up a fresh position across the Tawang Chu at Jang, leaving Se-la to be defended by the reinforcements that were being rushed up. Sen, despite having the authority to override Prasad, no longer had the confidence to follow his own instincts. Despite having landed in Tawang at 10.30 a.m. that morning, Sen had not felt it necessary to reconnoitre the terrain around Bum-la or its defences. Had he done so, apart from boosting the morale of the men on the ground, it would have been obvious to the army commander that Bum-la was not going to be a walkover for the Chinese and that it was a far cry from the tactically unsound position that 7 Brigade had been in at Nam Ka Chu. On the contrary, the army commander gave the distinct impression